4. Economic factors

Breast milk is the most economical food for the baby. Even after accounting the extra food cost required by the mother, breast milk is cheaper than any other type of artificial feed.

5. Psychological factors

Breast feeding is essential for a healthy, happy and emotional relationship between the mother and the infant.

6. Natural contraceptive

Breast feeding prevents the onset of another pregnancy and also prevents breast cancer.

7. Other advantages:

a. Infants jaw is more fully developed.
b. Breast milk is microbiologically sterile.
c. Human milk is always fresh and at the right temperature.
d. It is convenient to administer at any time.
e. Breast fed babies have better cognition and IQ later in life when compared to bottle fed babies.

Artificial feeding

Though breast milk is the best milk and there can be no substitute for it, there are certain circumstances during which the infant needs to be given artificial feeds.

Reasons

1. Illness of short duration like fever, or severe illness like tuberculosis and heart disease.
2. The mother is on steroids, anticoagulants or radioactive drugs.
3. Insufficient milk secretion.
4. Death of mother.

Premature Infants are born before 37 weeks of gestation

Solid food added to an infant's diet is called beikost

6.2.1.2 Complementary Foods and Weaning Foods

Milk provides all the food a baby needs for at least the first four months of life. As babies gain weight and grow older they need a more varied diet. The change over from milk to more solid food is called weaning. The idea of weaning is the process of gradual introduction to a wide range of 'non milk' foods to infants in addition to breast milk. Weaning the baby from breast or bottle feed starts by four months.

Stages of Weaning

Weaning is a transition from breast milk or formula milk to solid foods. It is divided into the following stages:

→ **STAGE I**- Babies are usually ready to start on solid foods between 4-6 months
→ **STAGE II**- 6-9 months
→ **STAGE III**- 9-12 months

Stage I

Babies cannot chew and the first weaning foods need to be similar in consistency to milk. Cereals such as rice or wheat flours mixed with milk is a suitable first weaning food. Food should be the same temperature as their usual milk feed. Mashed, pureed, starchy vegetables made to the same consistency are also suitable foods.

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